

Newtonian differs from modern physics in its frame of reference. Modern physicists know that some things are “true” from one perspective but not another. I remember an example from the college physics course I took a couple of centuries ago. Suppose clocks and sticks start moving very fast—approaching, say, the speed of light. Funny things start to happen. Moving clocks run slow and moving sticks get shorter. But the clocks and sticks haven’t changed, only our frame of reference has.

When you retire you change your frame of reference. You move from a world with work at the center to a playful, almost make-believe world with your life at the center. In my case I adopted an attitude of “go for responsible pleasure” instead of “go for the corner office.” From my new vantage point, if something makes me happy and it’s not irresponsible, it’s important in my life.

It takes a little imagination to take off your work hat and try on “responsible pleasure” before you retire. It’s not a change from “wrong” to “right” any more than Newton was “wrong” and the new physics “right.” But the change in point of view is essential if you choose to retire in midlife.

Responsibility comes first. Someone once said that being an adult is being responsible. That makes sense to me. Otherwise, I suppose, kindly people in starched white jackets would have to take care of us. But for my purposes “responsible” sets the bounds of behavior. I try not to hurt anyone. I treat my body and spirit with respect. I don’t do drugs or booze to excess. I don’t let myself get fat or lazy. I work hard at whatever I do. I try to treat myself seriously but not take myself too seriously.

For most of us, being responsible is second nature. We’re solid citizens, dependable parents, loving mates, and tough executives. We take to responsibility the way a rhinoceros takes to mud. The idea of living for pleasure, on the other hand, makes us squeamish. We profess to believe that pleasure is good, that happiness is what we want in life, but somehow we feel guilty when we enjoy ourselves.